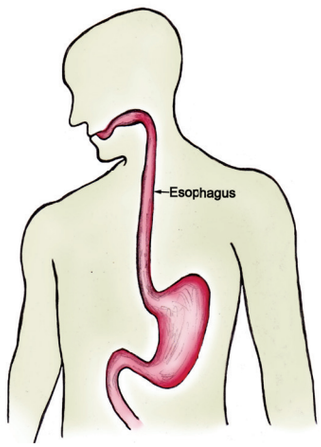
5.1 A Primary Source of Energy

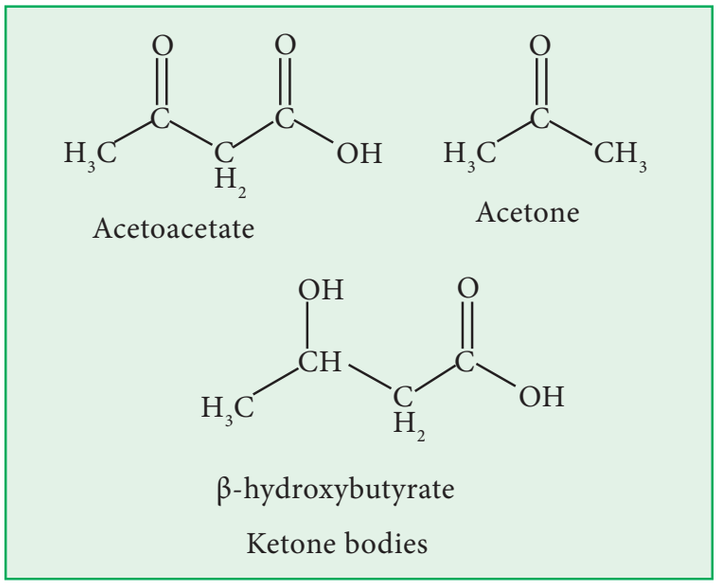
Digestion of carbohydrates actually starts in the mouth. Enzymes in saliva begin to break down carbohydrates. The Carbohydrates travel through the esophagus, stomach and enter the small intestine.



In the small intestine, carbohydrates get further broken down into single carbohydrate units called monosaccharide. These single molecules get absorbed across the intestine wall and are sent through the blood stream. Carbohydrate in the blood is in the form of a monosaccharide called glucose. The more carbohydrate eaten at one time, the more glucose is going to be released into the blood after digestion.

Now it is important to note, that fats and proteins can also be burnt to provide energy but fats are only burned if there is non-availability of carbohydrates. When fat is burnt in absence of carbohydrates, toxic compounds like called ketone bodies are produced.

Accumulation of these ketone bodies over long period causes a condition called 'Ketosis" In this condition, blood becomes unable to carry oxygen properly and this can be fatal. Thus, "one of the important functions of carbohydrate is to help burn fat properly".



i. As a source of energy:

The main function of carbohydrate is to supply energy for the body processes. A greater part of the energy in the diet (more than 50-80%) is supplied by carbohydrates.

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